International actors

The mushrooming of CSOs in southern Shan State is one of the most prominent features of the post-2010 political landscape. While these CSOs may have different objectives, they share several similarities. First, they receive financial support from international donors. The main patron of KRSAN is the National Endowment for Democracy (NED), an INGO funded by the United States Congress. Its three-storey office costs US$250 a month to rent, which is underwritten by the NED.[11] DEMO is also funded by the NED. In October 2014, the American Center in Yangon invited a senior officer in charge of DEMO to participate in a capacity-building workshop in New York for three weeks. The PYO is funded by the Open Society Foundation, an INGO backed by the famous financier George Soros. It also receives financial assistance from the Burma Relief Center, based in Thailand, and Volunteer Service Overseas.[12]

With foreign patrons, the CSOs do not need to rely on the Shan State political economy. Their leaders are very young, mostly under thirty. They are well educated, speak fluent English, are ideologically oriented towards democracy, and more importantly, they are politically mobilized. These young leaders' achievements motivate other youths to follow their causes. Working for CSOs has become an attractive alternative to being farmers in villages where job opportunities are few. This has inspired many young people to take English lessons at the KRSAN centre and to participate in activities organized by these CSOs. The involvement of the NED and Open Society invites speculation that these foreign donors are sowing the seeds for an Arab Spring-style uprising in Myanmar should the democratic transition falter, but in the short term at least, these international actors have empowered the pro-democracy actors in the Pa-O community to resist the state and its pro-establishment affiliates.

CO-OPTATION AND THE POLITICAL ORDER IN PA-O AREAS AND SOUTHERN SHAN STATE

The purpose of identifying the key political actors at the local, state, and international levels is to reveal how the political order in Pa-O areas and the southern Shan State is constructed and resisted. In a frontier area, the state needs to balance decentralization of authority and maintaining state control. From an authoritarian perspective, success in pacifying a